



Nokia adds Traffic

You can now get traffic update on your Nokia via Nokia Maps
<http://dgit.in/HmorRN>

Facebook Download tool

You can now download your personal account histories, chat conversations and IP addresses as well <http://dgit.in/HVnkEG>

CROWDSOURCING

Is it just a fad? Or is it really useful? We take a closer look at this 2009 internet buzzword to see if it's still relevant to us in 2012

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Crowdsourcing, a combination of the words "crowd" and "outsourcing," is the phenomena that powers one of the world's most visited sites, Wikipedia. It's increasingly finding application on the internet, in ways which you may have not even thought of.

Who, what, when?

For those unfamiliar with the term, crowdsourcing is simply asking a large bunch of people to perform a certain task. Put more elegantly, it is relying on a large, generally unknown, population of people to get work done. Although traces of pre-internet days exist, crowdsourcing today is primarily based off the web, connecting people from various geographies. Wikipedia is probably the best popular example of crowd power. It's a publicly editable encyclopaedia with a "neutral point-of-view." The site uses a combination of crowdsourcing and editors to ensure that the content on the site is updated frequently, with no factual errors.

Kickstarter, started in 2008, helps individuals and small groups of people set up a web page describing their project and asking people to pledge a certain amount of money towards the project – be it indie films, video games or food-related projects. Once the total amount pledged towards a project passes a threshold set beforehand by the project creators, the idea goes into "production" stage. The site's basic motive to spread creative ideas

and help them come to life has resonated well with the internet, with the site getting pledges worth more than \$175 million since its existence.

Current heartbeat

For crowdsourcing, the internet helped unlock a large group of people with a common aim. Take for example petition sites such as Change.org and Avaaz.org, which allow ordinary people to raise their voice for or against certain issues. During Anna Hazare's anti-corruption fast, more than five lakh Indians came together, in just 36 hours to support the campaign on Avaaz.org, which promotes activism on issues such as climate change, human rights, corruption, poverty, and conflict.

Even the Indian government turned to crowdsourcing when it decided that the Rupee currency needed a proper identification symbol. The Ministry of Finance, in 2009, announced a competition to create a symbol for the rupee, results of which were announced in July 2010. The symbol "₹" is now used officially in currency notes and coins.

Another category where crowdsourcing has really taken off is informa-

tion aggregation and curation on the web. There's so much content on the web, and the signal to noise ratio is very low, which means that discovering good content isn't an easy task. Sites such as Digg, Reddit, Slashdot and Hacker News attempt to bring some balance to this ratio by letting people submit links to web pages which blew them away, and people can vote on them. Links are then sorted according to the number of votes they get, thus surfacing good content. Just like Wikipedia, news aggregation sites such as Techmeme and Memerandum use a combination of crowdsourcing and editors to get the best of both worlds.

What's happening in India?

There's a lot more to do with crowdsourcing in India than the recent example of designing the Rupee symbol. Many organisations are using social media as a platform to gain information about their audience. Traffic police from various cities are encouraging residents to report traffic violations through Facebook; Parle, through its Twitter followers, gathered data about the availability of its products in various regions across India, and

